Associations and stories

Our associations

Associations are the connections that form between us and a colour. We are not born with a ready-made list "grey = this", and yet they tend to be surprisingly similar. They are usually made of three layers: **the body**, **culture** and **what we ourselves have lived through**.

From the body

Grey is the colour of **mist, stone, ash and animal fur**. It is the colour of things that recede or, on the contrary, quietly hold. That is why we perceive it as **neutral**, sometimes calm, sometimes cool.

From culture

In Europe grey was long linked with **offices, the city and the everyday**. But at the same time also with elegance and influence. Phrases like grey mouse, grey eminence or grey drabness each carry a different meaning. We will look at this in more detail in the chapter on cultures.

From what you have lived

The fur of an animal you like to touch, a peeling corridor where you waited for unpleasant news, a stone in the sun, a favourite jumper or a November city in which you were alone. These memories decide the most. **The same colour label, a completely different experience.**

When you know where your associations come from, it is easier to tell what is really "grey" and what is your story about it. You can ask yourself now. **What does grey connect with first for me, and where do I know it from?**

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Stories

Grey has several stories worth untangling. They show where the colour ends and where what people make of it begins.

A picture only in grey, grisaille

Grisaille is painting done exclusively in shades of black and grey, sometimes with a narrower range of colour. It was used **to imitate sculpture** in large decorations, as an underpainting for oil pictures where colour was added only later, and as a model for engravers. It was also quicker and cheaper than full colour, although sometimes it was chosen for aesthetic reasons too.

Giotto used it in the lower parts of the frescoes in the Scrovegni Chapel in Padua around **1304**. Pieter Bruegel the Elder painted Christ and the woman taken in adultery in grey tone in 1565. Grey here is not a lack of colour. It is **a decision to let light, shadow and volume speak for themselves**.

The Cistercians and the year 1134

In **1134** the Cistercians banned coloured art in their monasteries. The roots of grey stained glass, so-called grisaille, reach, according to an overview, to the twelfth century and to Cistercian monasteries. Grey glass let light through without bright colours.

Today grey in a church may seem cold to you. For monks it may have been a guarantee that nothing disturbs the light and prayer. The same colour, a different reason.

Grey eminence

Originally the name belonged to François Leclerc du Tremblay, known as **Père Joseph**, the right hand of Cardinal Richelieu, who in effect ruled France. Joseph was a Capuchin and wore their grey habit. More interesting than the colour itself was the contrast with Richelieu's bright red cardinal's robe.

He was never a cardinal, but around him he was called "eminence" because he stood so close to power. Today the word denotes a person with great influence who stands in the background. Grey here does not mean inconspicuousness. It means **influence that does not show itself**.

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